one another to form an aerial pseudostem. The central axis that is concealed at the bottom of the pseudostem in called shaft, which elongates and pierces through the pseudostem at the time of flowering and produces inflorescence terminally. (*Musa)* **monocarpic** Stem is aerial and woody in (*Ravenala madagascariensis.)*

Leaf: Simple with long and strong petiole, the leaf blade is large and broad with sheathy leaf base. The leaf is exstipulate. Oval, obtuse or oblong with a stout midrib, entire, numerous parallel veins extending up to the margin, rolled in bud. Phyllotaxy is spiral in *Musa* and distichous i.e. leaves are arranged alternately in two opposite vertical rows in *Ravenala*.

Inflorescence: Terminal or axillary thyrse of one to many monochasial branched spadix in *Musa*, Usually the flowers are protected by large brightly coloured, spirally arranged, boat shaped bract called spathe. Compound cyme in *Ravenala.*

Flowers: Bracteate, ebracteolate, sessile, trimerous, unisexual or bisexual or polygamous, when unisexual the flowers are monoecious. Flowers are zygyomorphic and epigynous. (In *Musa* flowers are polygamous i.e. staminate flowers, pistilate flowers and bisexual flowers are present in the same plant).

Perianth: Tepals 6, biseriate, arranged in two whorls of 3 each and homochlamydeous, 3 +3 syntepalous. In most of the species of *Musa,* the three outer tepals and two lateral tepals of the inner whorl are fused to form 5 toothed tube like structure called **abaxial lip**. The posterior inner median tepal alone is free, which is distinctly broad and membranous called **labellum**.

Androecium: Stamens 5 or 6, arranged in two whorls of 3 each opposite and adnate to the tepals. In *Musa,* only 5 stamens are fertile and the inner posterior stamen is either absent or represented by a staminode. In *Ravenala,* all the six stamens are fertile. Filaments free, anthers linear, dithecous dehisce by longitudinal slits, and with sticky pollen.

Gynoecium: Tricarpallary, syncarpous, trilocular ovary inferior, ovules many, axile, placentation, style filiform, stigma three lobed septal nectaries are present.

Fruit: Elongated thesh (*musa*) berry containing numerous seeds, fruits forming compact bunches, seeds with copious and small embryo in *Musa*. Capsule in *Ravenala.*

Seed: Larges, starch rich Endosperm (Ensete).

Botanical Description of *Musa paradisiaca.*

Habit: Monocarpic gigantic peremial herb.

Root: Fibrous adventitious root system.

Stem: The real stem is underground called **rhizomatous**. The apparent, aerial erect unbranched pseudostem is formed by the long, stiff and sheathy leaf bases which are rolled around one another to form an aerial pseudostem. The central axis that is concealed at the bottom of the pseudostem is called shaft. The shaft elongates, pierces through the pseudostem and produces an inflorescence terminally.

Leaf: Simple with a long and strong petiole. The leaf blade is large and broad with sheathy leaf base. Leaf exstipulate and obtuse pinnately parallel venation which extends upto the leaf margin phyllotaxy is spiral.

Inflorescence: Terminal branched spadix. Flowers are protected by large, brightly coloured spirally arranged, boat shaped bracts called spathe. When the flowers open, spathe rolls back and falls off.

Flower: Bracteate, ebracteolate, sessile, trimerous, unisexual or bisexual, flowers are zygomorphic and epigynous.

Perianth: Tepals 6, biseriate, 3+3 syntepalous, arranged in two whorls of 3 each

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